

# T. Ben Baker, PhD, JD

Assistant Professor, Colby College, Department of Philosophy

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## ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

- **Colby College, Assistant Professor** 2023–present  
Waterville, ME  
– Department of Philosophy, Davis AI Institute
- **University of Pennsylvania, Provost Postdoctoral Fellow** 2020–2023  
Philadelphia, PA  
– Kording lab, Departments of Bioengineering and Neuroscience

## EDUCATION

- **University of Pennsylvania, PhD Philosophy** 2020  
Philadelphia, PA  
– Dissertation: “Cognition in Nature: Information, Explanation, Embodiment”  
– Social, Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience, Graduate Certificate  
– Dean’s award for distinguished teaching by a graduate student
- **Yale Law School, JD** 2014  
New Haven, CT  
– Substantial Analytic Writing on Mens Rea and Manslaughter  
– Lowenstein International Human Rights Clinic
- **Brown University, BA (Concentrations in Philosophy (honors) and Economics)** 2010  
Providence, RI

## SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

### Peer-Reviewed Articles & Book Chapters

- **Use and Usability: Concepts of Representation** [\[link\]](#) 2026  
*with R Lange, A Richmond, R Cao, N Kriegeskorte, O Schwartz, X Pitkow, Neurons, Behavior, Data Analysis, and Theory*
- **Rethinking Artificial General Intelligence: Beyond Anthropomorphism** 2026  
*Invited book chapter, Introducing Philosophy of Mind, Today (eds. D Curry, L Daoust), Routledge*
- **Understanding Complexity Through Affordances** [\[link\]](#) 2025  
*with Sonia Roberts, Minds and Machines*
- **Computational Kinematics of Dance: Distinguishing Hip Hop Genres** [\[link\]](#) 2024  
*with T Liu, J Matelsky, F Parodi, J Krakauer, K Kording, Frontiers in Human Robotics and AI*
- **Three Aspects of Representation in Neuroscience** [\[link\]](#) 2022  
*with B Lansdell and K Körding, Trends in Cognitive Sciences*
- **Creativity in AI-Dance Art** [\[link\]](#) 2022  
*Proceedings of the International Conference on Computational Creativity*
- **Natural Information, Factivity, and Nomicity** [\[link\]](#) 2021  
*Biology & Philosophy*
- **Referee Report of (hypothetical) Philosophy101 Textbook** [\[link\]](#) 2021  
*Teaching Philosophy*  
– Spanish translation by Fredy H.P. Galindo, 2023, *Cuestiones Filosofía*

## Public Writing & Reports

- **Commentary on Favela and Machery** [\[link\]](#) 2023  
*Symposium contribution, The Brains Blog*
- **The Time is Ripe to Reverse Engineer an Entire Nervous System** [\[link\]](#) 2023  
*Position paper, Alliance for C. elegans Neural Dynamics (ACeND)*
- **What Does Engaged Philosophy Look Like?** [\[link\]](#) 2016  
*with L Daoust and R Willison, guest post, DailyNous.com*
- **Before Their Time: Challenges to the Prohibition Against Child Marriage in Sierra Leone** [\[link\]](#) 2013  
*with A Elbogen, S Keene, Allard K. Lowenstein International Human Rights Clinic*

## TEACHING

Instructor of record for 19 semester-courses (250+ Colby students through Spring 2026). Mean instructor rating 4.45/5 across evaluated sections. Frequency in parentheses where > 1.

### Courses

- **Colby College, Assistant Professor, Department of Philosophy** 2023–present  
Waterville, ME
  - All courses developed and first-taught by me
  - Central Philosophical Issues: Mind, Body & Machine (×6)
  - Philosophy of Dance (×2)
  - AI and Human Values
  - Philosophy of Emotion
  - Philosophy of Cognitive Science
  - Philosophy of Science
  - Bodies and Power
- **University of Pennsylvania, Instructor of Record, Department of Philosophy** 2018–2020  
Philadelphia, PA
  - Introduction to Philosophy (×2)
  - Philosophy and Visual Perception
  - Ethics

### Student Advising

- **Honors theses:** 1 in Philosophy; 1 in Computer Science (cross-departmental)
- **Senior independent studies:** 2 in Philosophy
- **January-term and summer mentees:** 4 students

## SELECTED TALKS

### Invited Talks

- **What Does It Mean to Be Human?** 2025  
*Invited all-school speech, Loomis Chaffee School, Windsor CT*
- **Rethinking Artificial General Intelligence** 2025  
*Oberlin Colloquium in Philosophy, Oberlin College*
- **Invited Commentator, Symposium on Technology and Cognition** 2025  
*Southern Society for Philosophy and Psychology, annual meeting*
- **Moving Between Genres: A Computational and Embodied Exploration of Dance** 2025  
*Invited contributor, Slippage: 3D Humanities Series, Northwestern University*
- **Dance Machines!** 2024  
*James Madison University, sponsored by the Philosophy & Religion Department and JMU Dance Program*
- **Six Forms of Dance Cognition** 2023  
*Mind the Body, University of Utah*

## Conference Presentations & Panels

- **So You Think AI Can Dance?** 2022  
*Eye, Mind, and Image: Themes from Visual Studies, UPenn*
- **Panelist, Symposium on Affirming Black Excellence in Neuroscience** 2021  
*Cognitive Neuroscience Society (virtual)*
- **Representation in Neuroscience** 2020  
*Neuromatch Conference 3.0 (virtual)*
- **The Factivity and Nomicity of Information** 2019  
*Southern Society for Philosophy and Psychology, Cincinnati OH*
- **Neural Dynamics and Inner Representations** 2017  
*Conference on Representing Reality, SUNY Potsdam*
- **Learning to Dance with Dynamic Systems** 2017  
*Graduate BEN Talks, UPenn (internal)*
- **Weakness of Will in Desire-First Accounts of Rational Action** 2015  
*Philosophers' Cocoon Conference, Tampa FL*

## COMPUTATIONAL KINEMATICS OF HUMAN MOVEMENT

- **Motion Capture & Data Collection (Kinelab)** 2024–present  
*Colby College*
  - Designed and built a markerless motion-capture system at Colby; data collection ongoing in collaboration with Veronica Romero (Colby Psychology) under a joint umbrella IRB
- **Movement Modeling (KineTrace)** 2025–present  
*Colby College*
  - Developing self-supervised next-window-prediction models trained on a custom biomechanical featurization of human movement (precursor: *Frontiers* 2024); early-stage collaboration with Amy Lavieri (Robotics, Automation, and Dance Lab, Germantown PA)
- **Responsible AI Grant (\$10,000)** 2026  
*Davis Institute for Artificial Intelligence, Colby College*
  - Supporting sabbatical research on responsible computational kinematics — algorithmic bias, interpretability, and movement privacy in markerless motion capture

## PROFESSIONAL SERVICE & LEADERSHIP

- **Departmental/College Service, Colby College** 2023–present
  - **Department of Philosophy** (2023–present): Clark Award and Pepper Prize judging (reading and scoring senior essays, coordinating prize text, presenting at the awards banquet); co-organizing the annual Philosophy Department Awards Banquet; reviewing honors-thesis proposals for the Honors Program
  - **Faculty Advisory Committee, Davis Institute for Artificial Intelligence** (2023–present): Planning around Colby's AI policies and tools, event organization
  - **Search Committees** (2023–2026): three for hires in Philosophy (one TT, two VAP); one for the Director of the Davis AI Institute; one as external reviewer for Psychology
  - **Lunder Institute for American Art, Faculty Advisory Group** (2024–2025): Planning and participating in initiatives around integrating museum resources and visiting fellows into the work and teaching of Colby faculty, handling internal grant funding
  - **Science Technology and Society Faculty Advisory Board** (2023–2025): Contributing to initiatives for the STS department around student participation, course options, and internal funding
  - **Reuman Reading Group Organizer** (2024–2025): communications, documentation, and publicity for Colby's 27-year-running faculty-student reading group in philosophy

• **Conference/Event Organization,**

2018–present

- **Philosophy Symposium** (Spring 2025, *Colby*): Organized annual public lecture on Ethics of Social AI, with student participation, sponsored by the Philosophy department and the Davis AI institute.
- **The Flavor Continues Residency Organizer** (2024, *Colby*): Coordinated residency for a Boston-based Hip Hop non-profit, offering community workshops, guest teaching in Colby dance classes, and a performance
- **Birge Lecture Co-organizer** (Fall 2023, *Colby*): Helped select speaker and support publicity for Colby’s annual Kingsley Birge Memorial Lecture in Sociology
- **Philosophy and Engagement Conference Co-organizer** (2019, *UPenn*): Collaborated on planning and executing an interdisciplinary conference exploring the intersection of philosophy and community engagement
- **Indian Philosophy Reading Group** (2019, *UPenn*): Managed communications around logistics and selecting readings for graduate student discussion group
- **Admitted Student Weekend Coordinator** (2018, *UPenn*): Organized accommodations, planned activities, and facilitated interactions between faculty and prospective graduate students during recruitment weekend

• **Peer Review,**

ongoing

- **Journal reviewer:** *Philosophical Psychology*; *Philosophy of Science*; *IEEE Robotics and Automation Magazine*; *Dance Research Journal*